

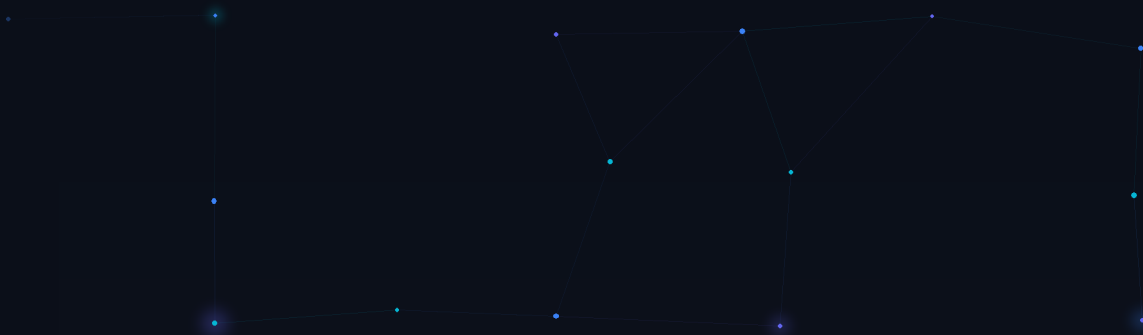


AI WEEKLY BRIEFING

This Week in AI

A self-contained briefing for our student, engineer, and PM community — models, research, policy, and what it means for what you're learning.

ISSUE — JULY 8, 2026 · 6 STORIES · NO OUTBOUND LINKS



Another fast week: two frontier model families moved, AI keeps closing in on drug discovery, and universities are turning AI literacy into policy. This issue is written to stand on its own — every story includes a plain-language takeaway, no clicking away required.

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MODELS

The Frontier Model Race Heats Up

Anthropic's Claude Sonnet 5 launched with introductory pricing of \$2 / \$10 per million input/output tokens (rising to \$3 / \$15 after August 31), while OpenAI confirmed preview details for GPT-5.6's Sol, Terra, and Luna variants — Sol claims a new state-of-the-art on Terminal-Bench 2.1, Terra matches GPT-5.5 at roughly half the cost, and Luna is built for speed. Gemini 3.5 Pro, meanwhile, is stuck in preview for a second straight week.

VERLIN LABS TAKEAWAY

PRODUCT MANAGERS · UNDERSTAND

Our PM track's Understand phase drills exactly this: reading a pricing/latency/capability table and matching the model to the job, instead of defaulting to whichever name is loudest that week.

Source: buildfastwithai.com (cited, not linked)

RESEARCH

AI Cracks Open Drug Discovery

AI models have now predicted the structure of more than 200 million proteins, accelerating vaccine and antibiotic research — and a University of Cambridge AI-designed vaccine component just completed its first human trials. Anthropic also launched Claude Science, a research workbench with 60+ preconfigured tools, alongside an internal drug-discovery program targeting neglected diseases.

VERLIN LABS TAKEAWAY

STUDENTS · DISCOVER

This is a favorite Discover-phase example for our Students track: it reframes AI as a general reasoning engine for science, not just a chatbot — the first mental model shift most 11th and 12th graders need.

Source: crescendo.ai (cited, not linked)

MATERIALS SCIENCE

Physics-Trained AI Finds New Materials

At the Ames Laboratory, a physics-trained model called DuctGPT is inventing rare-earth-free permanent magnets by reasoning about underlying physics rather than pattern-matching from data — an early sign of AI moving from prediction to genuine materials discovery.

VERLIN LABS TAKEAWAY

ENGINEERS · UNDERSTAND

A core mental model in our Engineers track: the gap between pattern-matching and physics-grounded reasoning. DuctGPT is a live, teachable example of a model reasoning from first principles instead of memorized data.

Source: [crescendo.ai](#) (cited, not linked)

POLICY

Washington Moves Toward Voluntary AI Rules

The White House is in advanced talks with OpenAI, Google, and Anthropic to finalize voluntary standards for releasing frontier models — covering safety benchmarks, testing timelines, and access rules — with an announcement possible as soon as next week. It follows a joint five-country cybersecurity advisory on agentic AI risk.

VERLIN LABS TAKEAWAY

PRODUCT MANAGERS · BUILD

Our PM track's Build phase includes shipping AI features under emerging disclosure requirements — this is precisely the kind of policy shift that changes what "production-ready" means for a real launch.

Source: [marketingprofs.com](#) (cited, not linked)

EDUCATION

Universities Get Serious About AI Policy

SUNY adopted a systemwide AI policy across all 64 campuses, embedding AI literacy into general education starting this fall, while Ohio's new mandate requires every public school district to have a formal AI policy in place by July 1. Separately, the NSF awarded \$11M to train 2,500+ K-12 teachers on AI fundamentals this summer.

VERLIN LABS TAKEAWAY

STUDENTS · DISCOVER

This is exactly why Verlin Labs exists: as more institutions mandate AI literacy, our free 2-hour session is built to give any student or teacher one clear mental model in a single sitting — no prior coding required.

Source: pursuit.us (cited, not linked)

INDUSTRY

The Hardware Squeeze

AI-fueled demand for memory chips has sent prices soaring — some are calling it “RAMageddon” — while major tech companies increasingly build their own energy infrastructure to keep pace with model training demands.

VERLIN LABS TAKEAWAY

ENGINEERS · SHOWCASE

In Showcase, our Engineers-track builders present projects that account for real constraints like this one — cost-aware model choice, not just raw capability — a habit we push from day one, not as an afterthought.

Source: artificialintelligence-news.com (cited, not linked)

BY THE NUMBERS THIS WEEK

200M+

protein structures now predicted by AI models

64

SUNY campuses adopting one shared AI-literacy policy

\$11M

NSF funding to train 2,500+ K-12 teachers on AI

HOW VERLIN LABS TURNS THIS INTO A SKILL

Every story above maps to a stage of the same framework we teach across all three tracks: **Discover** a real AI development, **Understand** the mental model behind it, **Build** something small that uses it, and **Showcase** it with a clear explanation. News becomes skill only when it moves through all four.

01

DISCOVER

02

UNDERSTAND

03

BUILD

04

SHOWCASE

Not sure where to start?

Book a free, 2-hour session and we'll help you pick the right track — School Students (6–12), College Engineers, or Product Managers. No commitment, no credit card.

[BOOK YOUR FREE SESSION →](#)

Verlin Labs

AI education, technology, and research for the next generation of builders.

You're receiving this because you're part of the Verlin Labs community. contact@verlinlabs.com